

Treasury Tries
Intervention
To Cut Rates

Upending Government’s
Role in Bond Market

By ALAN RAPPEPORT
and COLBY SMITH

The Trump administration’s Treasury Department has become increasingly interventionist in its efforts to bend the forces of global markets to lower the cost of living in the United States, but it is finding that success does not come easily.

The assertiveness comes as the U.S. gross national debt topped \$40 trillion on Wednesday, a milestone driven largely by growing interest payments to investors who hold government debt. High interest rates and elevated prices have combined to sour the views of voters on President Trump’s handling of the economy.

This week, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent made a surprising move to calm the jittery bond market. He announced that the Treasury Department would be doubling the amount of government debt it is permitted to buy back from investors. The increase was intended to limit the rise of long-term government bond yields as a way to contain borrowing costs.

“Part of this is signaling and to show that we believe that yields don’t reflect the underlying fundamentals,” Mr. Bessent said in an interview with CNBC on Thursday.

Explaining that he is willing to expand the buyback program, Mr. Bessent argued that investors are misreading the market.

“We are trying to keep the market in equilibrium,” Mr. Bessent added.

Those yields — which represent what investors are demanding to be paid in order to buy bonds — spiked to their highest levels since 2007. The yields, which move inversely to bond prices, dipped after Mr. Bessent’s announcement on Wednesday. By Thursday, yields were again rising, underscoring the challenge of such interventions given the fundamental issues that are making bond investors jittery.

Mr. Bessent has been trying other approaches to push down borrowing costs. The Treasury Department has been issuing more short-term bills that mature in less than a year to help keep interest rates lower. The strategy is similar to one that was used by Mr. Bessent’s predecessor, Janet L. Yellen. In 2024, Mr. Bessent criticized Ms. Yellen for deploying that approach, saying she was using

Continued on Page A13



ANATOLI STEPANOV/REUTERS

A resident was evacuated from an apartment building in Kyiv that Russian missiles struck on Thursday. The attack killed at least 15.

Will Map Fury
Lift Black Vote
In Alabama?

By EMILY COCHRANE

TROY, Ala. — Doug Jones, a former senator, and Shomari Figures, a current but endangered representative, have been here before in Alabama.

Mr. Jones lost his Senate seat in 2020 to Tommy Tuberville, a former college football coach, and now hopes to beat him in November in a contest for governor. Mr. Figures won a House district in 2024 that was redrawn to give Black voters more representation. Now he is confronting new district lines drawn explicitly to give his seat to a Republican.

Besides being Democrats, what both men have in common is a need for Alabama’s Black voters to come out in November in overwhelming numbers, energized and angered in part by the Supreme Court’s decision in April that weakened the Voting Rights Act and set off a new wave of redistricting in the South.

Continued on Page A14

A Region Shaped by Hardship Is ‘Left in Ruins’

By GENEVIEVE GLATSKY

CHOCÓ, Colombia — In Colombia’s remote Pacific region of Chocó, isolation has long been a fact of life. Roads are few, electricity and health care are limited, and much of the population lives in poverty while armed groups control parts of the territory.

Then came the earthquake. Already one of the country’s most vulnerable areas, Chocó was also the epicenter of a 7.4-magnitude quake that struck last week, killing at least 298 people across the country.

In Chocó, the full extent of the devastation is unknown, as the authorities struggle to reach communities scattered across the re-

Pain, Homelessness and
Hunger in Colombia
After a Quake

gion. Now, Chocó faces a reconstruction effort that will have to overcome the same geographic, economic and political barriers that have shaped the region for generations.

“We were left in ruins,” said Juan Fernando Taborda, 35, who does odd jobs in La Ye, a town of about 600 people two hours from Quibdó, the capital of Chocó, where most buildings were destroyed or damaged. “We have

nothing.”

For much of Colombia’s history, Chocó was a remote mining frontier where enslaved Africans were brought by the Spanish to work in the mines. Some escaped and formed communities beyond colonial control.

Basic infrastructure and public services lag far behind the rest of the country, while the rugged roads connecting it to major cities are plagued by difficult terrain and landslides. Out of Colombia’s 32 states, or departments, Chocó, with a population of about 600,000, ranks highest in poverty, according to government data.

A predominantly Afro-Colombian and Indigenous region on

Continued on Page A6



FEDERICO RIOS FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Soldiers and volunteers unloaded supplies in San José del Palmar, part of Colombia’s Chocó region.

Devotion to British Upbringing
May Be Behind a Royal Return

By MICHAEL D. SHEAR

LONDON — Fifteen months ago, Prince Harry said he could not “see a world in which I would be bringing my wife and children back to the U.K.”

The Duke and Duchess of Sussex had fled to America amid a seemingly irreparable royal rift, a vicious media environment and a British public that was angry

about their criticism of the monarchy. Harry told the BBC that it was “really quite sad that I won’t be able to show my children my homeland.”

Now, he will. In a move that appears to have caught even King Charles III by surprise, Harry and Meghan are planning to settle back in Britain in the coming weeks. Their children, Archie, 7, and Lilibet, 5, will enroll in school here. Royal watchers said the family would live in private accommodations outside London.

The question that quite a few people in Britain are asking is: What changed? The answer, royal observers say, may hinge in part on Harry’s longing to give his children the kind of upbringing that he remembers fondly — minus the public attention and press scrutiny that he has repeatedly denounced.

In 2023, Harry described Britain as “central to the heritage of

Continued on Page A8



NATHALIA ANGARITA/REUTERS

Prince Harry and Meghan, his wife, lived six years in the U.S.

As Personal Injury Suits Proliferate, Wall Street Enters the Game

This article is by Ellen Gabler, Robert Gebeloff and Julie Tate.

Danny Anguisaca-Morales was repairing a church facade in Manhattan when he appeared to fall. Security footage shows him climbing a few rungs up a ladder, leaning to his left, then dropping to the scaffolding below.

He filed a multimillion-dollar lawsuit, saying he had severe injuries and PTSD, and could no longer work.

Personal injury cases like his

Funding for Claimants
Results in Big Payoffs

can take years to resolve, so to support himself, Mr. Anguisaca-Morales turned to a company known as a consumer legal funder.

Such firms float cash advances to plaintiffs to cover expenses like rent, food and medical care while their cases go through court. The advance is similar to a loan, ex-

cept that if a case fails, the plaintiff doesn’t have to pay it back.

But most of the time, insurance companies settle personal injury cases, and the plaintiffs repay their advances — plus fees and interest of 35 to 45 percent a year, on average. One woman in New York who said she turned her ankle on a sidewalk, for example, received \$76,500 in advances and ended up owing at least \$1.4 million to her funder by the time her case settled, court records show.

Behind the scenes, The New

York Times found, Wall Street has figured out how to profit from it all.

Some of the consumer funding industry’s biggest players are bundling thousands of these i.o.u.s together to create asset-backed securities, the financial products that were made infamous during the 2008 mortgage crisis and have come roaring back.

Asset-backed securities allow investors to buy a stake in the fu-

Continued on Page A12

NATIONAL A11-19

Arrest in Albany Bomb Plot

Prosecutors say a woman met with an F.B.I. informant to plan an attack on the New York State Capitol. PAGE A18

Gas Station, or Casino?

A legal loophole in Pennsylvania has kept so-called skill games, below, from being considered gambling. PAGE A11



INTERNATIONAL A4-10

A TikTok Star Is Born at 89

Werner Kalecinski is a social media sensation among young Germans. How did he go from heartbroken widower to partying on a yacht? PAGE A4

An Uneasy U.S.-Iran Standoff

For weeks, there has been no diplomatic progress, but also no full-scale fighting, as each side seems to believe the other will fold first. News Analysis. PAGE A9

Africa’s Richest Man’s Windfall

Africans, and others, have turned to an oil refinery in Nigeria as the war in Iran has affected the global supply. PAGE A10

BUSINESS B1-6

A College Boom, of Debt

Families in India are betting on private universities as a path to a better life. It isn’t always working out. PAGE B1

Sluggish Sales for Walmart

Big retailers have warned that shoppers were being cautious, even if household finances seem healthy. PAGE B1

OBITUARIES A20-21

ZZ Top’s Beardless Drummer

Frank Beard, 77, propelled the band’s blend of boogie, Southern rock and blues for over a half-century. PAGE A20

SPORTS B7-10

Mahomes and Ertz Team Up

The Chiefs quarterback and the Commanders tight end became each other’s motivator after knee injuries. PAGE B10

Premier League Predictions

What will the table look like? Which of the nine new managers will do best? Our writers offer their views. PAGE B7



WEEKEND ARTS C1-8

Beyond the Standards

The pianist Sullivan Fortner excels at playing jazz classics. But a new album of his own songs also stands out. PAGE C1

Dutch Architect’s Ohio Gem

While nearly all the homes designed by Gerrit Rietveld are in the Netherlands, one is in America’s heartland. PAGE C1

OPINION A22-23

Thomas L. Friedman

PAGE A23

